

**Workers Without Work:
Pigeons and the Infrastructural Afterlife of Domestication**

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Abstract

When an institution stops needing an animal's work, the lives organized around that work continue. Pigeons show the mismatch clearly: their capacities for homing, reproduction and life near people outlasted many of the institutions that employed them. We trace the withdrawal of those institutions through histories of pigeon keeping, disposal records, animal retirement statutes and the urban control literature, and call their uneven retreat *distributed decommissioning*. Comparisons with horses, military dogs and research chimpanzees separate the power to dispose of a worker from the acceptance of responsibility after work. Sale, adoption, sanctuary and statutory protection of unowned populations are distinct settlements, and the disappearance of a task determines none of them. The pigeon record also shows a capacity once valued as a service, reliable homing, becoming an objection to the continued presence of the birds that have it. Ecology and material harms shape this process, yet neither population counts nor control costs settle the question of obligation. The argument rests on the difference between arranging another use for an animal and recognizing a claim that no longer depends on its usefulness.

Introduction

When Project Pigeon lost its funding, B. F. Skinner had equipment to scrap and birds to keep. Thirty pigeons were retained to test how long their trained responses would last. Six years later, he reported, a bird could still respond correctly to its former target (Skinner 1960, 34, 36).

The program ended before the competence it had produced, and the birds still needed feeding the next morning. Skinner found a further use for them in measuring the persistence of a skill the original project no longer required. That arrangement kept their care within the terms of an experiment and left open what would be owed once no further experiment remained.

Street pigeons pose the same question in a less orderly form. Their domestic ancestry connects them to lofts, agricultural estates, message services and households whose purposes changed at different times. No single authority closed these arrangements, and some forms of pigeon keeping continue. The historical problem concerns a working relationship that loses its purpose without acquiring an agreed ending for those whose lives it organized.

Pigeons make the problem visible because they can live beyond the organization that employed them. Their survival depends on food, nesting sites and their own capacities as well as on the loss of a job. Discarded equipment can also leave lasting obligations: a reactor or an oil well remains hazardous after production stops. A pigeon differs in having interests of its own. It continues to suffer or flourish, and its descendants occupy places in which no institution has arranged for them to belong.

Working arrangements and distributed decommissioning

A pigeon post required more than a bird able to find its way home. It needed lofts, breeding, handlers, transport away from home and a route along which a return flight could carry information. Reuter's contract with Heinrich Geller in April 1850 divided these responsibilities in writing.

Geller was to supply and dispatch trained pigeons for the Brussels–Aachen route, and Reuter bore the transport costs. The supplier was released from replacing birds lost on the journey. The initial term was three months, unless Reuter’s enterprise ended sooner (Reuter and Geller 1850, secs. 1–3, 7–10). The contract set an end date for the service. It made no corresponding promise of retirement. Its silence on the birds’ later care is a limit of the record and does not show that they were abandoned.

Other arrangements valued other capacities. In the pigeon towers near Isfahan, manure collection linked birds, nesting structures and an agricultural market. Ownership attached the birds and their product to a landlord (Beazley 1966). Droppings were a product with a buyer, and their later status as damage to city buildings depended in part on the loss of that system of collection and sale.

The working animal belonged to an organization of places and expectations. Barua’s account of non-human life as infrastructure describes how animal capacities become parts of a larger operation (Barua 2021). Coulter’s account of animal work places the worker’s well-being within the discussion (Coulter 2016). Once well-being is admitted, the end of a service cannot be assessed only by the savings or improved performance of its replacement.

Relationships with pigeons also persisted where a commercial use declined. Jerolmack’s ethnography of New York rooftop flyers describes how birds organized neighbourhood knowledge, competitive status and social ties across ethnic divisions (Jerolmack 2009). Affection and inherited practice could sustain a loft that no message business needed. Edgerton’s account of technologies that persist, disappear and reappear on different schedules argues against a single chronology of replacement (Edgerton 2007).

Distributed decommissioning names the withdrawal of working arrangements by different actors, on different schedules, without a common settlement for the animals left outside them. Closures and neglect coexist with continuing forms of keeping, from which birds may also escape. Genetic work connects feral populations with domestic breeds, including racing pigeons (Stringham et al. 2012). It cannot reconstruct the founders of an arbitrary city flock. The historical records identify routes out of institutional care; they do not establish a single line of descent from a dismantled service to every bird on a street.

This unevenness bears on the allocation of responsibility. Each closure can appear complete from the position of the organization making it. Taken together, the decisions leave a population that none of those organizations counts as its remaining business.

Disposal, retirement and the end of custody

The United States Army could close its pigeon service because its birds belonged to an identifiable organization. When the Fort Monmouth lofts closed in 1957, surviving veterans went to zoos or collections and roughly 1,000 other birds were sold. The sale took place on 23 March (National Agricultural Library, n.d.). The inventory was cleared by transferring custody. The record shows where the Army took its responsibility to end; it says nothing about how the birds fared afterwards.

Urban horses passed through a longer chain of employers as their capacities declined. Rendering gave even a dead horse an economic value. McShane and Tarr's account includes a St. Louis firm's 1896 claim of a \$24 profit per carcass (McShane and Tarr 2007, 27–28). A sequence of remaining uses supplied a route to disposal. None of its stages required a settlement in which the animal's needs outlasted its exchange value.

Ownership alone does not explain the difference from pigeons. Horses had different feeding costs, reproductive patterns and requirements for urban space, and their absence from large feral populations in those cities is no controlled test of an institutional theory. The comparison does expose the distance between the power to dispose of an animal and a duty to care for it after work.

Retirement statutes make that distance explicit. The United States military-dog law enacted in 2000 authorized adoption, subject to a suitability decision by the unit commander informed by veterinary advice. Adoption was not promised to every dog, and the law excluded federal liability for the adopted dog's later veterinary expenses (Military Working Dog Adoption Act 2000, § 1). It provided a way to move care to a new keeper.

The CHIMP Act made a different arrangement for designated surplus research chimpanzees: a sanctuary system with a duty of lifetime care. Its original provisions prohibited discharge from the system while permitting limited research and euthanasia in the animal's interests (CHIMP Act 2000, § 2). A continuing institutional obligation could thus be separated from an animal's remaining value to a particular project.

Ownership is not a prerequisite for every such obligation. The 1971 Wild Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act defined a protected population of unbranded and unclaimed animals on federal public lands. The statute also provided for management, including removal and, under specified conditions, destruction (Wild Free-Roaming Horses and Burros Act 1971, §§ 1–3). Protection did not assure the survival of every animal. It assigned public duties toward an unowned population and required conflicts to be resolved within that responsibility.

These settlements distribute risk differently. An adoption can fail, an institution can underfund care, and a population-level duty can permit severe intervention against individuals. The distinction holds despite those failures. Ending work, transferring custody and ending obligation are separate decisions. Technological replacement settles none of them automatically.

Pigeons as an urban control problem

The control literature describes the animal after its capacities have ceased to count as contributions. Williams and Corrigan's 1994 handbook entry warns that relocated pigeons may return from more than 50 miles away or create a problem elsewhere (Williams and Corrigan 1994, E–95). The homing ability that made a bird valuable to its keeper is here the reason removal fails. The bird retains its competence and loses the place that competence once secured.

The reversal is neither universal nor purely verbal. A racing pigeon can foul a neighbour's roof, and an unowned flock can have devoted carers. Different valuations coexist, and the practical

question is whose valuation authorizes a decision about the birds. Jerolmack's history of New York reporting traces a shift from complaints about birds in particular locations to a broader category of the pigeon as a troublesome urban animal, with public-health claims forming part of its justification (Jerolmack 2008). A history of work and custody helps explain what that category leaves out. It does not by itself explain the timing of a campaign or the differences between cities.

The harms require attention. New York City's health guidance distinguishes ordinary encounters from dust exposure during cleaning and identifies particular concern for people with compromised immune systems (New York City Department of Health and Mental Hygiene, n.d.). Recognizing those hazards leaves open which responses are proportionate, and whether the needs of the animals enter the decision at all.

The accounting of nuisance can obscure the same question. Pimentel and colleagues' estimate of \$1.1 billion in annual United States pigeon damage used an assumed density and an estimated control cost of \$9 per bird per year. Potential control expenditure served as a proxy for losses (Pimentel et al. 2000, 56). The estimate was not a national survey of realized damage, and money spent preventing a presence can differ substantially from the harm that presence causes. When a population appears only as a cost of removal, the accounting can make the decision to remove it look settled in advance.

Ecology sets a further limit on the institutional account. In Barcelona, an intervention combining public education with culling was associated with a 40% fall in pigeon density in two districts between February and June, without a corresponding change in the comparison district. Analyses within one district linked the decline more closely to reduced food availability than to culling effort (Senar et al. 2017). The treatments were not isolated by random assignment, and movement between areas may explain some of the change. Food availability nonetheless belongs in any account of persistence. An obligation toward a population does not exempt its management from these material questions.

Residence in infrastructure

A station canopy shelters passengers and may also shelter nesting birds above them. Star's account of infrastructure emphasizes that its character depends on the position of its users: what enables one activity may obstruct another (Star 1999). Pigeons occupy parts of buildings whose assigned purpose makes no provision for their residence.

The history of their work therefore has a spatial continuation. Animals once incorporated into a communications network can also inhabit infrastructure whose managers want them absent. Barua describes this repurposing as part of the relationship between infrastructure and non-human life (Barua 2021). The conflict arises whether or not a given bird on a station roof descends from a message carrier.

Feral nonspace names a site that supports animal habitation while its managers treat that habitation as unauthorized. Nets, spikes and altered ledges enforce that judgment materially. They change where birds can settle and leave the birds' need for a place to settle unchanged. Philo and Wilbert's

distinction between places allotted to animals and places animals make for themselves keeps both uses in view (Philo and Wilbert 2000).

Some sites require exclusion, and a hospital ventilation shaft poses a different question from an unused industrial roof. Moving birds from one building to another can nonetheless leave the question of their residence unanswered at the scale of the city. An owner may have resolved a complaint while no authority has decided where the excluded population can live.

Obligation after usefulness

A history of employment might support a claim of repayment, in which care is owed for services rendered. For city pigeons that argument meets an immediate difficulty. Many have never performed a task for a keeper, and their particular ancestry cannot be recovered. A claim that depended on proof of former service would leave much of the population outside it.

Donaldson and Kymlicka's account of liminal animals offers another starting point. Their idea of denizenship recognizes animals living among people without being owned by them: residents owed protections, though not full members of a shared citizenship (Donaldson and Kymlicka 2011, ch. 7). Residence and an ongoing relationship can ground claims that an account of productive contribution misses.

The ethical premise adopted here is that lives shaped around an institution's purposes do not become irrelevant to its decisions when those purposes change. Where the original institution has disappeared, present relationships, capacity to act and the interests of those affected must inform the allocation of responsibility. Historical involvement gives a reason to ask who should act; it cannot specify a budget or confer a right to every ledge. Membership, in this limited sense, means a standing claim to consideration in decisions about a shared place. Particular uses of that place remain open to dispute.

A managed loft is one possible way to make such a claim administratively visible. It gives care an address and assigns someone the task of providing it. That attraction is not evidence of effectiveness. Giunchi and colleagues' 2012 review reported a lack of quantitative evidence for the population-control efficacy of urban dovecotes with egg replacement (Giunchi et al. 2012). Any present proposal would need to assess welfare, movement and displaced conflict as well as numbers. The institutional question precedes the choice of this or any other device: whether the population enters the decision as a subject of care or only as a presence to be reduced.

Finding the birds another use would answer a different question. Skinner could retain them for a new experiment, and a fancier could value their performance. Such arrangements can sustain care, but they make it depend on another demand. A continuing claim would matter in the cases where no replacement task could be found. Accepting it would change the terms on which the relationship ended.

Pigeons remained after their work ended: embodied, reproductive and present in places that no longer assigned them a purpose. Their history shows that technological systems can abolish a

function faster than societies determine what is owed to those who performed it. Usefulness can end before membership does.

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